

**REVIEW OF THE OPERATIONS OF THE NSW RECONSTRUCTION
AUTHORITY REGARDING THE NSW EAST COAST SEVERE WEATHER FROM
MAY 2025**

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NSW Government Submission to the Joint Select Committee on the NSW Reconstruction Authority

Review of the operations of the NSW
Reconstruction Authority regarding the NSW
East Coast severe weather from May 2025

27 October 2025



Acknowledgement of Country

The NSW Government acknowledges the Traditional Custodians of the lands where we work and live. We celebrate the diversity of Aboriginal peoples and their ongoing cultures and connections to the lands and waters of NSW.

We pay our respects to Elders past, present and emerging and acknowledge the Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander people that contributed to the development of this submission.

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1 Executive Summary

The Joint Select Committee on the NSW Reconstruction Authority (the Committee), is required to review the operations of the NSW Reconstruction Authority (RA) relating to a disaster. This inquiry is focused on the RA's response to the May 2025 East Coast severe weather event and other related matters. In line with the Australian Government's system of cataloguing disasters for which natural disaster declarations have been made, the incident has been given the Australian Government Reference Number: AGRN 1212.

AGRN 1212 was a significant and complex disaster, affecting regions still recovering from ex-Tropical Cyclone Alfred and earlier events. The response, transition, and ongoing recovery efforts have involved extensive collaboration across Government agencies, Non-Government Organisations and community groups.

The NSW Government remains committed to supporting disaster-affected communities through coordinated, responsive, and evidence-based recovery programs. The RA has been leading these recovery efforts consistent with its legislative role and functions. The RA's leadership is shaped by multi-agency collaboration and strategic oversight, and is evolving in line with best practice and community expectations.

The NSW Government welcomes continued consultation and collaboration with the Committee as the Inquiry progresses.

2 Terms of Reference A: Changes and improvements to the operations of the Reconstruction Authority

Item a) of the Committee's Terms of Reference relates to *the Authority's response to, and any changes or improvements to the operations of the Authority, the following recent disasters:*

- i) the severe weather caused by ex-Tropical Cyclone Alfred from 3 March 2025,*
- ii) the major electricity outages affecting Far West NSW from 17 October 2024,*
- iii) the catastrophic floods affecting the Central West region in 2022, and*
- iv) any other disasters that were subject to a Natural Disaster Declaration and in which the Authority exercised its functions.*

2.1 Coordination and strategic planning

Across 2024–25, the RA led the delivery of a range of initiatives designed to embed lessons from previous disaster events into a more coordinated, consistent, and structured approach to recovery, particularly in the post-transition, early recovery phase where operational tempo and community need are highest. The RA continues to play a central role in coordinating the Government's recovery efforts following AGRN 1212.

This has included:

- The early activation of Natural Disaster Declarations which enabled timely mobilisation of resources and planning.
- The development of Recovery Action Plans and the establishment of a Recovery Planning Data and Insights Taskforce, in preparation for ex-Tropical Cyclone Alfred earlier in 2025, have been significant steps toward improving strategic oversight and data governance. The Taskforce provided a whole-of-government co-ordination point for gathering, accessing and analysing data to inform recovery operations and program delivery. This included working closely with the Department of Customer Service to co-ordinate leveraging existing platforms.
- The RA, in partnership with the Premier's Department, is currently reviewing the NSW Impact Assessment Guidelines to provide more accurate and comprehensive impact assessments that can inform recovery operations in a timely fashion.
- Informed by previous disasters, the RA has trialled new frameworks such as the Recovery Coordination Framework. This framework has been generally well-received and considered beneficial for structuring response and recovery phases.
- A key outcome has been the development of an enduring Recovery Framework and Practice Guide which aims to build and sustain individual and team capability through a culture of continuous learning and improvement; and will provide consistent, practical guidance on the ground.

These initiatives have been tested and refined across multiple declared natural disasters, with learnings captured and incorporated into current operational frameworks and guidance. The NSW Government has noted areas for continued improvement, such as further embedding RA representation at Local Emergency Management Committees to improve local planning and coordination.

To support the recovery, given the scale and complexity of AGRN 1212, the NSW Government appointed a dedicated, independent Recovery Coordinator to manage the early stages of the recovery. The Recovery Coordinator, former NSW Deputy Police Commissioner Dave Owens APM,

oversaw broader Government recovery efforts, led the establishment of Regional Recovery Committees, and facilitated direct engagement with Councils, community organisations and Aboriginal communities to ensure locally informed and inclusive recovery planning. The Recovery Coordinator role was transitioned to a Senior Executive of the RA from 3 September 2025. A recovery plan was developed which is informing the RA's continued recovery response to AGRN 1212. The RA will carry out an After-Action Review by end-2025 to determine lessons learned and continue to improve future preparedness and recovery operations.

2.2 Operational improvements

The RA has implemented several operational improvements as part of its response to AGRN 1212. These include enhanced early deployment of personnel, surge staffing models and community outreach initiatives. Targeted outreach to Aboriginal communities through culturally safe recovery hubs were highlighted as positive developments. Agencies also noted improvements in internal communications, financial tracking and the use of structured data updates to support situational awareness. The RA's improved collaboration with other NSW Government agencies, Councils, community groups, Non-Government Organisations, and businesses has facilitated streamlined emergency works, standardised damage data capture and more efficient clean-up operations.

Following Ex-Tropical Cyclone Alfred, the RA partnered with NSW State Emergency Service (SES) to conduct outreach and impact assessments across affected Local Government Areas, identifying early recovery needs within communities. The intelligence gathered informed the establishment of the Recovery Centres, Recovery Assistance Points and outreach locations.

Following housing challenges after the 2022 Northern Rivers floods, the RA commissioned the Living Lab Northern Rivers to develop a best-practice framework for disaster-affected housing. Released in June 2025, the report guided the RA's response to AGRN 1212, including the decision not to establish temporary housing villages.

The RA has recognised the importance of embedding its personnel within Incident Management Teams and leveraging existing systems for better data sharing. The use of Disaster Impact Forms and tailored support for vulnerable populations, including Aboriginal communities, were seen as effective practices. After-action reviews following major disasters is noted as having been a key driver in improving and refining recovery operations.

2.3 Challenges encountered

Despite improvements, several challenges were identified in the transition from response to recovery in the early recovery phase of AGRN 1212. The transition from response to recovery was at times unclear to supporting agencies, despite the RA and SES, as the combat agency, having a clear understanding of their respective functions.

The RA works closely with combat agencies throughout both transition from response to recovery, and the recovery phase itself. Recovery commences during response, and it is important to acknowledge that the transition from response to recovery is not linear – for example, in AGRN 1212, some communities were moving to recovery as others were still in response phase.

The approach taken during AGRN 1212 reflected work the RA has been leading with the NSW RFS and SES over the previous 12 months to develop a more structured approach to the transition from response to recovery. A set of Standard Operating Procedures (SOPs) detailing the process have been developed, as have a suite of supporting documents. The intent of this process, led at the State level but informed by the local and regional situation, is to ensure the State Emergency Recovery Controller (SERCON) is fully cognisant of the situation on the ground before the transition occurs. This will enable the RA to have effective coordination, planning and support arrangements in place from the point of transition, and in turn ensures no loss of support or service delivery to the impacted community. The RA is continuing to build understanding of these arrangements ahead of the 2025-26 High Risk Weather Season through a series of pre-season briefings with SES and RFS.

There remain opportunities to improve the RA's coordination of the transition to recovery. A key gap identified by the NSW Government was the transition of clean-up activities between the SES and

the RA. In recent disasters these activities, such as washing out homes, were completed during the response phase, often with support from Disaster Relief Australia (DRA) before transitioning to the RA. However, the RA does not currently have the operational capability to undertake these tasks, and SES was unable to continue them beyond the response phase. In this instance, the RFS provided support, with the RA coordinating through an Incident Management Team (IMT).

The NSW Government has identified that central coordination in collection and sharing of damage and impact data would bring significant benefits for NSW in future disaster events. Standardisation of software platforms and data formats would allow agencies to integrate systems more easily, creating a clearer picture of recovery needs.

There was a clear enhancement in collaboration between Homes NSW and the RA, particularly through co-development of the Housing Support Package. However, there is still opportunity to refine and expedite these processes, especially the transition of roles and responsibilities during the shift from emergency accommodation to temporary accommodation.

3 Terms of Reference B: Exercise of planning powers under the RA Act

Item b) of the Committee's Terms of Reference relates to *the exercise of any planning powers under the Act in the affected region, including:*

- i) powers under Parts 6 to 7 of the Act following a Ministerial declaration under Part 5, particularly the power to compulsorily acquire land,*
- ii) land and housing buybacks and disposals*
- iii) the effectiveness of housing resilience programs, and*
- iv) developments subject to a ministerial authorisation order under section 68 of the Act.*

3.1 General comments

The RA did not exercise its planning powers in response to AGRN 1212. However, there have been several occasions where the RA has exercised its planning powers in response to previous weather events. The RA's planning powers remain important regulatory tools for the NSW Government that enable transparent and equitable land acquisitions, aligning resilience programs with hazard mitigation strategies and supporting emergency operations through temporary protection works.

Most recently following a request from Central Coast Council, the RA quickly convened a multi-agency working group to assess risks and provide recommendations to address coastal erosion and associated damage to property and the environment which had been compounded by storms in March and April 2025. The RA declared a 'Reconstruction Area' under section 40 of the RA Act, after which the Council submitted a request to the RA seeking the Minister for Recovery issue an authorisation under the RA Act to complete necessary works for an area in The Entrance North. Following due consideration, on 4 July 2025 the Minister issued an authorisation under sections 68 and 69 to implement temporary coastal protection works, with conditions for monitoring and decommissioning.

Government experts in coastal erosion, planning, engineering and environmental policy contributed to the consideration of the request and the development of conditions for the works. This collaborative inter-agency process has been subsequently used to provide expert input in the development of other section 68 conditions.

Since the RA's establishment, section 68 powers have been exercised where community safety and timeframes were critical, including for school rebuilds at Broadwater, Blakebrook and Lismore South Public Schools.

3.2 Observations

Acknowledging that under the current legislative framework Councils have an important role to play in managing coastal risks, the RA will consider potential improvements that have been canvassed by stakeholders, such as the development of standardised hazard playbooks with defined triggers and alternatives, legal pathway mapping across relevant legislation, cross-agency legislative reform to enable holistic operations and pre-agreed safety treatments supported by agile legislative options. It was observed that there is a need to enhance collaboration between agencies and to enhance Councils' understanding of the powers.

There is a shared emphasis on the importance of clear protocols around the exercising of powers under the RA Act, particularly section 68, to support Local Government understanding and engagement. It was noted that some confusion exists at the local level regarding the powers of the Local Emergency Operations Controller (LEOCON) to issue emergency orders, pursuant to section 61 of the State Emergency and Rescue Management Act 1989 (the SERM Act), which are separate to temporary or permanent works covered by powers under the RA Act.

4 Terms of Reference C: Communication and community engagement

Item c) of the Committee's Terms of Reference relates to *how the Authority and relevant agencies communicated to and engaged with affected communities in the delivery and design of reconstruction and preparedness efforts, including whether principles of community-led recovery and culturally appropriate emergency management were considered.*

4.1 Community engagement and recovery coordination

Since its establishment, the RA has sought to embed community-led recovery principles into its operations in affected communities. This was demonstrated in early coordination of recovery efforts for the AGRN 1212 event, which prioritised the application of local knowledge to recovery planning as well as transparency in communication and decision making with local agencies.

This was exemplified in RA establishing weekly briefings with State and local community organisations throughout the event which ensured that recovery information was shared consistently. This work was enhanced by financial support for initiatives such as the Mid Coast Council's Youth Recovery Forum. This Forum enabled community members to have a voice in shaping their own recovery pathways. At its peak, weekly briefings from the RA attracted over 200 participants and served as a space for collaboration and communication where up-to-date recovery information was shared between agencies to ensure timely and coordinated recovery efforts. Agency representation in these briefings included the RA, NSW Health, the NSW Department of Communities and Justice, and the local Primary Health Network as well as local service providers across the Hunter and Mid North Coast.

The briefings also provided an avenue for local service providers to raise emerging themes and concerns, fostering two-way communication, which often led to improved community recovery outcomes.

The NSW Government found that these briefings enabled meaningful networking among community groups, allowing needs to be shared and matched with offers of support or solutions. This collaborative environment improved access to recovery services and information, strengthened regional and interagency relationships and provided opportunities for culturally safe engagement. It supported service delivery adaptation, real time communication and problem-solving for immediate assistance and community supports.

The RA has also partnered with grassroots organisations to deliver services in familiar and trusted settings. Events such as the Manning Valley Community Cuppa and outreach through groups like the Taree Lions Club and Harrington Resilience Association allowed recovery efforts to be integrated into existing community networks. These approaches reflected a deliberate strategy by the RA to meet people where they were, physically, culturally, and emotionally. RA teams continue to liaise with, and work alongside, local community networks across the region to strengthen local capacity and coordination for future recovery efforts.

4.2 Culturally appropriate emergency management

The NSW Government incorporated lessons identified from previous disasters to the AGRN 1212 response by including a much greater focus on Aboriginal-led recovery support. This support was coordinated by the RA with support from Service NSW and other partners. The RA recovery support was informed by early engagement with organisations including (but not restricted to) Aboriginal Community Housing Providers, Local Aboriginal Land Councils and Aboriginal Medical Services.

The RA implemented new, targeted Recovery Assistance Points at locations identified by Aboriginal communities themselves. These hubs were co-designed and delivered by Aboriginal organisations, elders and Aboriginal Medical Services, to create culturally safe spaces for community engagement.

The NSW Government used these Recovery Assistance Points to prioritise informal, welcoming environments that were designed to minimise queues, reduce anxiety and encourage participation. Aboriginal Liaison Officers played a central role in facilitating respectful communication, while the presence of Aboriginal staff helped build trust. Feedback from communities indicated that this model significantly improved access to services and strengthened relationships between the NSW Government and Aboriginal communities.

4.3 Multi agency contributions to recovery and engagement

NSW Government agencies worked collaboratively to support recovery efforts and ensure meaningful engagement with affected communities. This collaboration was underpinned by a shared commitment to community-led recovery and culturally respectful practices.

Since the conclusion of AGRN 1212, the NSW Government is maintaining recovery collaboration through a Recovery Committee and Sub Committees. Representation on these groups includes Councils, Government agencies, business groups and community organisations. A Recovery Action Plan has been developed to guide recovery efforts across the footprint.

Crown Lands, Transport for NSW and the RA coordinated to address access issues and accelerate engineering assessments. They engaged early with Aboriginal land councils to ensure culturally appropriate recovery works. NSW Public Works supported infrastructure and waste management recovery, including the appointment of a First Nations Liaison Officer as well as the facilitation of regional waste committees that supported and empowered Councils to lead clean-up operations.

During response and recovery operations, Combat agencies play a vital role in providing both operational support and community engagement activities in partnership with the RA. Informed by outcomes from previous disasters, the NSW State Emergency Service (SES) has worked extensively with the RA on preparedness initiatives across NSW. Recent examples include the Macksville Community Evacuation Exercise, North Rivers Flood Risk Awareness Project, Manning Point Flood Hypothetical, Purfleet Aboriginal Land Council Preparedness Project and Aged Care and Community Services Preparedness Workshops. Similarly, the Rural Fire Service (RFS) has used its strong community ties, provided trusted communication channels and supported culturally respectful engagement, to engage with local communities and organisations.

The RA collaborated with Service NSW and the Department of Customer Service to implement a comprehensive communications approach, including geo-targeted outreach. The RA also proactively undertook outreach with impacted Councils to ensure early commencement of emergency works and clean up.

An infrastructure working group and waste forums were established to facilitate collaboration and communication between State agencies and the relevant offices at the impacted Councils.

Through these forums, the RA worked collaboratively with Councils, Transport for NSW and the Environment Protection Authority to rapidly assess disaster impacts, develop early strategic estimates for emergency and immediate reconstruction works, and inform planning for longer-term Essential Public Asset Restoration.

The NSW Government developed guidance materials to support Councils in understanding disaster waste clean-up, eligibility and processes and through the relevant Disaster Recovery Funding Arrangements funding categories. This provided the clarity required for clean-up works to progress without delay to assist the community recovery in a timely manner.

Based on feedback from highly impacted Councils, an advanced payment mechanism was established to assist with cashflow during the emergency works and immediate reconstruction works period.

4.4 Observations

The ongoing recovery from AGRN 1212 has demonstrated the NSW Government's commitment to community-led recovery, preparedness and culturally appropriate engagement. However, challenges were noted, including sometimes inconsistent representation from the RA in Local Emergency Management Committees (LEMCs) and the absence of a formal mechanism for sharing recovery lessons across regions through LEMCs. RA's formal membership on LEMCs is relatively new, having been commenced at the beginning of 2025.

Strengthening integration and transparency of RA personnel with trusted local networks, including LEMCs, building partnerships with local RFS and SES units, and formalising successful engagement models were identified as key opportunities for improvement. The RA is undertaking a program of work to build capability through recovery exercising with LEMCs.

Formalising successful models such as the First Nations-led Recovery Access Points, targeted outreach and rapid engineering assessments would enhance future recovery efforts. Embedding these approaches into statewide guidelines and operations will ensure that recovery is not only effective but also inclusive and respectful of community leadership.

The RA, supported by a network of Government agencies, continues to demonstrate a strong commitment to community-led and culturally appropriate recovery for AGRN 1212. Through collaborative planning, established State and local partnerships, and innovative engagement strategies, the RA continues to help communities navigate the challenges of recovery with dignity and resilience. Continued refinement of these approaches will ensure that future disaster recovery is even more responsive, inclusive and effective. A Recovery Committee is still active for AGRN 1212 and continues to meet fortnightly.

5 Terms of Reference D: Effectiveness of preparedness and adaptation work

Item d) of the Committee's Terms of Reference relates to *the effectiveness of any relevant preparedness and adaptation work by the Authority for the affected region before the disaster*.

5.1 Local preparedness initiatives

In the lead-up to AGRN 1212, the RA undertook a number of preparedness and adaptation initiatives designed to strengthen community resilience and enhance coordination across all levels of Government.

The RA supported the establishment of Community Resilience Networks in the Mid-Coast and Port Macquarie-Hastings Local Government Areas, with efforts underway to re-establish similar networks in Nambucca and Bellingen. These networks, underpinned by the RA having previously funded and deployed Community Recovery Officers, played a critical role in disseminating recovery messaging and mobilising local support in the immediate aftermath of the disaster.

Community Resilience Networks also contributed to the development of Pre-Event Recovery Plans, which identified priority actions to be taken immediately following a disaster. This proactive approach enabled more rapid and coordinated recovery efforts.

The RA's strong relationships with local Councils, emergency management personnel, other government agencies and Non-Government Organisations further supported these efforts. This included direct engagement in Emergency Operations Centres, weekly coordination meetings with Council General Managers and elected officials, liaison with Local Emergency Operations Controllers and Local Emergency Management Officers, activation of Regional Recovery Committees, coordinated public messaging and targeted support for small and medium enterprises.

5.2 Statewide preparedness programs

At the State level, the RA implemented the 'Get Ready NSW' program, an all-hazards community preparedness initiative that delivered emergency warning education to Mid Coast communities in mid-2025. Complementing this, the 'Get Ready NSW Survey', which is currently underway, will provide Local Government Area-specific insights into household preparedness, enabling the RA to further tailor its initiatives to local needs once complete.

The RA also developed the Local Social Preparedness Assessment, a collaborative framework designed to identify critical local actions and investment priorities. While pilots of this assessment were underway in other regions at the time, the model presents a valuable opportunity for future application in the Mid Coast and beyond.

5.3 Agency contributions to preparedness and adaptation

During the response and recovery to AGRN 1212, NSW Government agencies undertook a range of preparedness and adaptation efforts. This included providing coastal and flood management advice, financial assistance to local Councils, and planning support through floodplain and coastal management programs.

Infrastructure and environmental preparedness activities were also undertaken. NSW Public Works, the RA and local Councils worked together to develop a regional waste strategy for the Mid-North Coast, which incorporated local knowledge and streamlined procurement processes to support disaster response. In addition, condition assessments of levees were conducted in the Hunter and Mid Coast regions prior to AGRN 1212.

Emergency services played a key role in preparedness coordination. The SES integrated recovery considerations into Incident Management Teams and State Command Centres, enhancing coordination with the RA. Post-impact community liaison campaigns and data collection tools were deployed to inform recovery strategies.

In the business and social services space, Service NSW Business Concierges provided case management support to small businesses, aiding both recovery and future preparedness. The Department of Communities and Justice facilitated preparedness coordination for vulnerable populations, including people sleeping rough, through sector collaboration and improved access to emergency information.

5.4 Challenges encountered

Despite these efforts, challenges were identified. Some Councils raised a need for dedicated emergency management staff, limiting their capacity to fully implement and engage with RA-led initiatives.

Stakeholder feedback on the timing of Recovery Assistance Point (RAP) establishment was mixed. Some stakeholders have expressed that RAPs could have been activated earlier during the response phase and recommended that supporting agencies could help with decisions about when and where RAPs are established to better align with the closure of evacuation centres. Importantly, services and support continued to be available and provided to community members throughout these transitions. Mixed feedback from stakeholders and agencies indicates that closer coordination is needed between when RAPs open and when evacuation centres close, ensuring continuity of support for community. The timing of when and where RAPs open will continue to be informed by the priority of the response phase and matters such as preservation of life, property and safe access to community.

There is appetite for a strategic shift towards disaster risk reduction and resilience, however progress in this space will require coordinated efforts across all levels of Government and additional investment in community partnerships. The level of investment in risk reduction and resilience through the Commonwealth Disaster Ready Fund and provisions of the Disaster Recovery Funding Arrangements (DRFA) have been acknowledged as needing review.

5.5 Reflection

The RA demonstrated a proactive and structured approach to preparedness and adaptation in the lead up to AGRN 1212. Its initiatives, particularly in community engagement and pre-event planning, contributed positively to early recovery efforts. However, feedback from agencies highlights the ongoing need for improved coordination, flexibility and sustained engagement to ensure that preparedness translates effectively into recovery. Strengthening collaboration across agencies and local councils, embedding RA personnel in operational planning and aligning recovery activation with community behaviours are critical to enhancing future disaster resilience across NSW. Continuous improvement is essential in any disaster recovery and is recognised as a key priority of the RA.

The development of Disaster Adaptation Plans is a core part of the NSW Government's strategy to reduce current and future risk from all natural hazards including bushfires, coastal hazards, earthquakes, floods, heat waves, landslides, storms, cyclones, tornadoes, and tsunamis.

Developed collaboratively between Government agencies, Councils and the community, Disaster Adaptation Plans will guide investment in adaptation and mitigation at a regional and local level. They will draw on hazard and risk reduction options identified through existing Council-based hazard management arrangements such as the NSW Floodplain Management and Coastal Management Programs. Delivered at the regional scale, Disaster Adaptation Plans identify where natural hazard risk can be mitigated, through a range of risk reduction tools like mitigation or evacuation infrastructure or land use planning controls. Where risk can't be mitigated, Disaster Adaptation Plans help communities adapt to their natural hazard risk, for example through home modification or community awareness programs. The RA has two Disaster Adaptation Plans

currently underway in the Hawkesbury-Nepean and the Northern Rivers and is working with 5 Council Joint Organisations (Canberra, Hunter, Illawarra-Shoalhaven, Riverina-Murray and Central West) to guide early disaster adaptation planning work which will progress to a Disaster Adaptation Plan.

6 Terms of Reference E: Application of funding under Joint Disaster Recovery Funding Arrangements

Item e) of the Committee's Terms of Reference relates to *the application of any relevant funding under the Joint Disaster Recovery Funding Arrangements, including the implementation of any recommendations arising from the Colvin Review published in October 2024.*

6.1 Funding coordination and strategic investment

The RA has a lead role in coordinating funding packages across multiple disaster recovery programs such as the provision of emergency accommodation, grocery vouchers, personal hardship grants, grants for low-income households to replace damaged goods, low interest loans for small businesses and primary producers and assistance to Councils to help with cleanup and emergency infrastructure repairs.

To support communities impacted by AGRN 1212, the RA collaborated closely with Homes NSW to design a \$50 million housing support package, providing essential funding for household repairs, emergency accommodation, temporary accommodation in the form of pods and caravans, and support for renters.

Informed by feedback from Councils and the community in previous grants, in the days immediately following AGRN 1212 the NSW Government worked with the National Emergency Management Agency and the Australian Government to set up a \$19 million Community Recovery Support Fund. This fund was approved by the Prime Minister on 23 May and enabled funding to be quickly provided to impacted Councils and communities.

6.2 Agency collaboration and program design

The RA is engaging extensively with agencies and non-Government organisations, including GIVIT, Service NSW, NSW Health, Legal Aid NSW, NSW Department of Climate Change, Energy, the Environment and Water, the NSW Environment Protection Authority (EPA), and the Small Business Commission to explore potential opportunities for further community support. Feedback from these agencies via Regional Recovery Committees and associated sub-committees informed the development of tailored support packages. This collaborative approach ensures programs and ongoing supports are evidence-based and responsive to sector-specific challenges.

Significant collaboration has occurred throughout the AGRN 1212 recovery process. Initially, daily meetings with Council directors responsible for infrastructure and/or waste, the EPA, Public Works and the RA were held to develop early planning for waste disposal and identification of temporary waste hubs. This co-ordination between NSW Government agencies and Councils enabled expedited clean-up efforts across impacted communities.

The RA is also working closely with Service NSW and Aboriginal Affairs NSW to increase engagement with Aboriginal communities. NSW Government agencies responsible for social recovery support are partnering with local and national non-Government organisations and a cross-agency working group has been set up, led by the EPA, to address the significant riverbank erosion which occurred as a result of AGRN 1212.

6.3 Operational challenges and implementation

Agencies have highlighted operational challenges in delivering recovery measures, including delays in damage assessments, resource constraints at the Local Government level, and the complexity of coordinating clean-up activities across jurisdictions. The RA's efforts to quickly embed Recovery

Support Services and Community Recovery Officers within Councils were seen as critical to addressing these challenges and empowering local recovery leadership.

6.4 Implementation of Colvin Review Recommendations

The RA's approach reflects key recommendations from the Colvin Review, particularly in enhancing coordination, transparency, and community engagement.

The NSW Government acknowledges improvements in governance and program delivery, while noting areas for further development, such as the potential for further streamlined funding mechanisms and clearer eligibility guidelines for disaster recovery support. It is noted that the Australian Government has not yet responded to the recommendations of the Colvin Review, which restricts the States' ability to implement them.

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review of the operations of the NSW Reconstruction Authority regarding the NSW East Coast severe
weather from May 2025

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